

# Morning Edition

SATURDAY, 26 SEPTEMBER 2026

*Ten stories, filtered through SHORE Institute, ocean governance, and Shorelines.*

01 · 100 Ratifications, Zero Institutions

02 · The \$200,000 Seychelles Is Eligible For

03 · 28.7% and Three Weeks Left to Register

04 · Mapping With Consent

05 · The Stack You Don't Have to Build

06 · Seychelles's \$10.48 Million Bet

07 · Contract Extended, Rulebook Delayed

08 · "If Funded" Is the Whole Problem

09 · A Sink That Could Become a Source

10 · The Deadline You Missed

**STORY 01**

# BBNJ Just Hit 100 Ratifications. The Institutions Still Don't Exist.

*The treaty behind SHORE's own ocean governance argument just crossed 100 ratifications, and its first Conference of the Parties has yet to build a single one of the institutions that will decide whether that number means anything.*

## STORY NOTES

The BBNJ Agreement reached 100 ratifications on 25 September 2026. IUCN Director General Dr Grethel Aguilar called it "an important achievement for the ocean and for multilateral cooperation," while pressing for the ratification wave to translate into "effective, fair and science-based implementation."

What's actually outstanding: the first Conference of the Parties still has to establish the Scientific and Technical Body, the Clearing-House Mechanism, financial arrangements, and rules of procedure. That is the entire operating architecture of the treaty, built from zero, nine months after entry into force.

IUCN's own priority list for that build: ground it in the best available science, guarantee SIDS and developing states equitable access to finance and technology, make the Clearing-House Mechanism genuinely usable rather than a registry nobody consults, and coordinate with the ocean governance bodies that already exist instead of duplicating them.

**<https://ecomagazine.com/news/policy/bbnj-agreement-reaches-100-ratifications-as-iucn-calls-for-science-based-implementation>**

#### STORY ARTICLE

A hundred ratifications reads like an ending. For BBNJ it is a starting gun. The agreement entered

into force on 17 January 2026, nine months after crossing the 60-ratification threshold on 19 September 2025. Forty more states signing on since then is a genuinely fast pace for a multilateral ocean treaty. But the pace of ratification tells you nothing about the pace of institution-building, and that second clock has barely started.

Four builds are outstanding at the first Conference of the Parties, and each one decides something concrete. The Scientific and Technical Body decides whose science counts when a marine protected area gets nominated. The Clearing-House Mechanism decides whether a capacity-building or technology-transfer request from a state like Seychelles gets matched to a partner, or sits in a directory nobody maintains. Financial arrangements decide whether the treaty's funding commitments are a disbursement schedule or a promise. Rules of procedure decide whether a SIDS voting bloc can actually hold a line when a wealthier bloc wants a different outcome.

Name the objection directly: the International Seabed Authority is the standing counter-example, two decades into building comparable institutional architecture and still unable to finish its own rulebook (see story 07 in this edition). Why would BBNJ's first COP do any better? The honest answer is that BBNJ's drafters were explicit about designing decision procedures to avoid the ISA's consensus trap, where near-unanimous agreement is required among states with sharply divergent interests. Whether that design intention survives contact with COP1's first real disagreement is the actual test, not the ratification count.

IUCN's four implementation priorities matter because they are not abstract. Equitable finance access and a usable Clearing-House Mechanism are the two points where a state like Seychelles will actually touch this treaty, when trying to secure capacity-building support or get a marine spatial tool recognised. A Scientific and Technical Body that can't absorb a submission from a body like SHORE reproduces exactly the access-gap

problem covered elsewhere in this edition (see story 04). The institutions being built right now are the difference between a treaty SHORE can use and one it can only cite.

No COP1 date has been confirmed in current reporting. That is itself worth flagging rather than glossing over: the story to track from here isn't the ratification tally, it's the agenda item list once a date and venue are set, and specifically whether finance and Clearing-House design get scheduled early or get pushed to a later session once the easier procedural items are out of the way.

**<https://www.ioc.unesco.org/en/bbnj-agreement-successfully-ratified>**

 URGENT

**STORY 02**

***A \$200,000 Commonwealth Grant Just Opened. Seychelles***

# *Is Already Eligible.*

*Seychelles's government can apply for up to US\$200,000 from a Commonwealth fund built for marine protection and climate resilience, and the only reason nothing has moved yet is that the application details still aren't public.*

## STORY NOTES

The COP29 Presidency–Commonwealth Fund for Small Island Developing States was announced on 23 June 2026 at London Climate Action Week, timed to CHOGM 2026 in Antigua and Barbuda. Grants of up to US\$200,000 are available to each of the 25 Commonwealth SIDS, drawn from a US\$5 million fund running over five years.

The fund is structured to back one government-backed project in each eligible state, with priority given to climate mitigation and adaptation, marine protection, sustainable fisheries, nature-based solutions, early warning systems, climate risk planning, and resilient renewable infrastructure. It builds on an existing relationship: an earlier

Commonwealth-Azerbaijan collaboration has already disbursed an initial US\$2 million from a US\$10 million pledge for SIDS environmental resilience.

No application process or deadline has been published yet. The Commonwealth's own announcement says further detail "will be published on Commonwealth in due course."

**<https://thecommonwealth.org/news/commonwealth-and-cop29-presidency-invite-commonwealth-sids-submit-climate-action-proposals>**

#### STORY ARTICLE

Do the arithmetic first. Five million dollars, split across twenty-five states, over five years, structured as one project per state rather than a shared competitive pool. That is real money against a small-state budget, and a materially different proposition from the SIDS funds that announce a headline total and then evaporate into administrative overhead once divided twenty-five ways.

It also isn't a cold start. The Commonwealth-Azerbaijan collaboration behind this fund has already disbursed an initial US\$2 million of a US\$10 million pledge for SIDS environmental resilience, which means there's a working disbursement relationship and a delivery track record sitting behind this announcement, not just a first-time promise.

Name the objection: multilateral SIDS funds routinely get captured by whichever state has the strongest existing grant-writing capacity, not the strongest need, and pooled-competition structures reward exactly that. This fund is a genuine departure from that model. Seychelles isn't competing against twenty-four other states for a shared pot. If it applies credibly, it has its own allocation to fill.

Her own institutional history is directly relevant here, not incidentally. Years as Director General for Maritime Boundary Delimitation and as a UNDP regional project manager put you on the

government side of exactly this kind of proposal before. The practical question right now isn't whether the fund is worth pursuing, it's whether Blue Economy or Environment ministry counterparts in Seychelles are already tracking it, or whether SHORE needs to be the one raising it with them before the call goes live.

The priority areas overlap directly with SHORE's own technical offer. Marine protection and sustainable fisheries both depend on the spatial data SHORE is built to provide, which is a specific opening: positioning SHORE as a technical partner on a government-backed proposal, since the grant itself is restricted to governments, not NGOs or research institutes applying directly.

Nothing is submittable yet. The watch item is [thecommonwealth.org](https://thecommonwealth.org) for the formal call, and the concrete move now is a conversation with Seychelles's own government departments about co-designing a proposal before that call opens, not after.

<https://thecommonwealth.org/news/commonwealth-and-cop29-presidency-invite-commonwealth-sids-submit-climate-action-proposals>

 URGENT

STORY · 03

# 28.7% of the Seafloor Is Mapped. Registration for the Next Push Closes in Three Weeks.

# 28.7%

OF THE GLOBAL OCEAN FLOOR NOW MAPPED TO THE GEBCO\_2026 STANDARD

*Registration for the one ocean-mapping event most likely to intersect with your own Seychelles bathymetry work closes on 16 October, and it's*

*the room where GEBCO Grid contributions for this region actually get decided.*

#### STORY NOTES

The GEBCO\_2026 grid, released in April 2026, put global seafloor mapping at 28.7% of coverage to modern standards, roughly 104 million square kilometres, after almost 5 million square kilometres were added over the past year.

The live event attached to that figure: the Seabed 2030 Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting & Data Sprint, hosted by Malaysia's National Hydrographic Centre at the Concorde Hotel, Kuala Lumpur, 20-22 October 2026. In-person registration has closed, but online and hybrid registration remains open until Friday, 16 October 2026. Invitation-letter requests go to [pacific@seabed2030.org](mailto:pacific@seabed2030.org).

The programme runs a hybrid plenary on regional mapping activity Tuesday and Wednesday, with an in-person data sprint on metadata preparation, formatting, and best-practice training for GEBCO

Grid contributions running Wednesday and Thursday.

<https://seabed2030.org/2026/06/19/seabed-2030-indo-pacific-ocean-mapping-meeting/>

#### STORY ARTICLE

28.7% sounds like a science statistic. The meeting attached to it is a governance room, not a laboratory. Every BBNJ area-based management tool, every ISA mining code boundary claim, every marine spatial plan depends on whose bathymetry gets treated as ground truth, and that gets decided in rooms like this one, not in the published grid itself after the fact.

The GEBCO\_2026 grid carries land and ice surface elevation data as its primary product, with a separate version including under-ice topography for Greenland and Antarctica. That level of granularity is now the working standard. What the Indo-Pacific meeting exists to fix is regional unevenness: the basin it covers, which includes the Western Indian

Ocean, has lagged other regions in coverage momentum across recent cycles.

Name the objection: a data sprint sounds like a technical workshop, low priority next to a governance meeting on treaty text. It isn't.

Contributions accepted or formatted at an event like this one get built permanently into GEBCO's authoritative record. Miss the room, and a region's own bathymetric identity in the global standard product gets written by whoever did show up.

Seychelles's exclusive economic zone runs enormous relative to its landmass, and the country's own visibility in a global bathymetric standard is a direct HARMONiSE and Ocean Mapping Hub concern, not an abstract mapping-community one. Getting a SHORE-affiliated technical contact into that Kuala Lumpur room carries more weight for the Hub's credibility this quarter than most governance meetings currently on the calendar.

Online and hybrid registration for the 20-22 October meeting closes 16 October, fewer than three weeks from today. Whether or not attendance is possible in person, the concrete task now is confirming who, if anyone, is representing the Western Indian Ocean at this meeting, and following up on what gets logged there once it concludes.

<https://seabed2030.org/2026/06/19/seabed-2030-indo-pacific-ocean-mapping-meeting/>

04

## **Marine Data Needs the Same Consent Standard as Any Other Extractive Industry**

*The argument that marine data governance needs the same consent standards as any*

*extractive industry is the exact gap  
HARMONiSE's data-sovereignty chapter has  
been reaching for, and it now has a name and  
named case studies behind it.*

#### STORY NOTES

"**M**apping with consent" is the proposal that communities and nations become equal stakeholders in how marine data about their own territories is collected, used, and shared, rather than passive subjects of someone else's survey.

The governance gap it names is specific: UNCLOS gives limited guidance on data ownership and access; IOC-UNESCO relies on voluntary commitments, which produce weak obligations and limited coordination; institutional fragmentation across exclusive economic zones and areas beyond national jurisdiction compounds both.

Two case studies anchor the argument: Indonesia's community-led mapping of customary fishing grounds, which fed directly into marine spatial

planning decisions, and participatory mapping by fishing communities in Chennai and Mumbai documenting coastal zones and resource-use patterns for governance input. Recommendations include treating marine data as a public good, applying Free, Prior and Informed Consent principles, and investing in domestic infrastructure and regional cooperation through bodies such as IORA.

**<https://www.orfonline.org/expert-speak/mapping-with-consent-towards-equitable-marine-data-governance>**

#### STORY ARTICLE

**H**ere is the uncomfortable structural fact underneath most ocean data infrastructure: advanced economies hold the high-resolution seabed mapping and ocean observation capacity, developing states hold the data gaps, and that asymmetry translates directly into who gets excluded from blue economy sectors, offshore

energy licensing, deep-sea mineral claims, not just who gets cited less often in the literature.

The legal gap is precise, not vague. UNCLOS is largely silent on data ownership. IOC-UNESCO's coordination model runs on voluntary commitments, which is a polite way of saying no state is actually bound to share what it collects, or to let another state weigh in on how its own waters get surveyed. That is a genuine vacuum, not a minor gap awaiting a technical fix.

The Indonesia and Chennai-Mumbai examples matter because they are proof of concept, not just critique. Community-authored, participatory mapping fed directly into governance decisions in both cases. These were not advocacy documents filed and ignored. They changed what marine spatial planning actually looked at.

Name the objection directly: "open data" advocacy in ocean science sometimes assumes that publishing raw high-resolution data widely is itself the equity fix. In practice it can relocate the

extraction problem rather than solve it, handing the same asymmetric advantage to whichever actor has the compute and expertise to exploit an open dataset first, now under a more comfortable open-access label. That is precisely why the recommended fix is a Free, Prior and Informed Consent framework, not blanket openness. Consent standards decide who gets to use data and how. Openness alone decides nothing.

IORA is the regional body that matters for her own geography here, and the gap is nameable directly: no equivalent forum currently does for the Western Indian Ocean what these examples demonstrate for Southeast and South Asia.

This is the theoretical scaffolding HARMONiSE's data-sovereignty chapter has been reaching for without yet having comparable named case studies to cite. Reading the full piece against that chapter directly, and treating Indonesia and Chennai-Mumbai as the citable precedents currently missing

from it, is worth doing this week rather than filing this as background reading.

---

<https://www.orfonline.org/expert-speak/mapping-with-consent-towards-equitable-marine-data-governance>

STORY · 05

## // copernicus\_marine + geoai: the mapping stack you don't have to build

*Europe's Copernicus Marine Service just got a formal role supplying free data for marine spatial planning, and the GeoAI workflows built alongside it are already validated for reef and illegal-fishing detection, which is most of the Ocean Mapping Hub's tooling stack sitting there unbuilt-by-you.*

## STORY NOTES

\$ Mercator Ocean International ran a "Marine Data for Maritime Spatial Planning" workshop in Brussels in March 2026, demonstrating how the Copernicus Marine Service supplies free, science-based ocean data specifically for MSP use cases.

\$ Alongside it, GeoAI workflows for marine ecosystem monitoring have been validated across three distinct use cases and scales: coral reef segmentation from underwater orthomosaic imagery, fishing-vessel detection and classification from satellite imagery to estimate fishing effort, and marine species and habitat segmentation from geolocated underwater images.

\$ Together this is free, publicly available infrastructure a resource-constrained institute can plug into, rather than build from scratch.

#### STORY ARTICLE

Marine spatial planning has always been bottlenecked less by planning method than by who owns the underlying ocean data feeding it. A free, science-based, continuously updated data service changes who can credibly run an MSP process at all, not just how fast they run it.

Copernicus Marine's role is straightforward: it aggregates satellite, in-situ, and modelled ocean data streams and makes them freely available, with the March workshop specifically framing that supply around MSP use cases rather

than general oceanographic research.

The three GeoAI use cases are worth taking one at a time. Coral segmentation on underwater orthomosaics automates reef habitat mapping at a scale manual annotation can't match. Vessel detection and classification on satellite imagery estimates fishing effort as a proxy, with an immediate application to monitoring illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing. Species and habitat segmentation on geolocated underwater imagery extends the same approach to biodiversity mapping. All three have been validated across multiple sites and scales, not demonstrated once and generalised from a single case.

Name the objection: "validated" in a European research context does not automatically mean transferable to tropical, high-biodiversity, island-state reef and seafloor conditions. Seychelles's water clarity, sediment type, and species composition differ enough from the validation sites that a direct lift-and-use approach risks quietly wrong outputs dressed up as validated science.

The direct application to HARMONiSE and the Ocean Mapping Hub is real regardless: this is a tooling stack that could underpin the Hub without SHORE needing to run its own satellite programme. The fishing-vessel detection use case specifically has an immediate SIDS-relevant application,

monitoring illegal fishing across an EEZ far larger than Seychelles's patrol capacity can cover directly.

The concrete next step is checking whether Copernicus Marine's data catalogue already covers the Western Indian Ocean at usable resolution before assuming a data gap that needs filling independently, and testing the GeoAI workflows against known Seychelles reef sites before trusting their outputs at face value.

**<https://events.marine.copernicus.eu/marine-data-for-msp-2026>**

# Seychelles Just Signed a \$10.48 Million Bet on Its Own Blue Economy Argument

*Seychelles's government just signed a \$10.48 million project meant to operationalise the blue-green economy transition SHORE has been arguing for on paper, and whether it becomes usable data or another donor-reported PDF depends on who gets named a technical partner now.*

## STORY NOTES

UNDP and Seychelles's Ministry of Environment held the inception workshop for "Enabling the Transition to a Blue

## STORY ARTICLE

Draw the distinction that matters first. "Blue economy" as a slogan is one thing. This is a financed project with a specific GEF-8 funding

and Green Economy in the Seychelles" on 21 August 2026, a GEF-8-funded project worth US\$10.48 million.

Participants spanned government institutions, development partners, civil society organisations, academia, the private sector, and community representatives.

The stated aim is to scale up efforts to protect Seychelles's natural heritage while advancing sustainable, inclusive economic development.

line and a signed inception date behind it, which is a different order of commitment entirely.

GEF-8 is the eighth replenishment cycle of the Global Environment Facility, competitive and results-based. Seychelles had to make a results case to secure this allocation. It did not arrive as a standing entitlement.

Name the objection: inception workshops are the easy, photogenic part of any donor-funded project. The harder test is

<https://www.undp.org/mauritius-seychelles/press-releases/seychelles-launches-landmark-blue-and-green-economy-project-drive-nature-positive-development>

whether the results framework built around it actually produces spatial data a body like SHORE can use, or whether it becomes another set of donor-reported indicators nobody outside the ministry ever touches again.

The High-Income SIDS Paradox is not an abstract argument here, it is this project. Seychelles's GDP per capita hit roughly US\$17,670 by April 2026, the highest in Africa, and the country still qualifies for concessional GEF

funding designed for capacity-constrained states. That contradiction is live in a single signed project, not a talking point.

The concrete watch item is whether SHORE, or a comparable local research body, gets named as a technical or data partner in the project's results framework, not just represented at the inception workshop's stakeholder table.

Workshop attendance and technical-partner status on a GEF results framework are very

different levels of involvement in what the project actually produces.

Following up directly with Ministry of Environment contacts on that results framework and M&E structure is worth doing now, while it is still being finalised, rather than after the document is locked and the partner list is already set.

<https://www.undp.org/mauritius-seychelles/press-releases/seychelles-launches-landmark-blue-and-green-economy-project-drive-nature-positive-development>

STORY 07

# The Seabed Regulator Extended a Mining Contract Instead of Finishing the Rulebook

---

*The UN's own seabed regulator just gave a mining contractor five more years while still failing to finish the Mining Code, and the*

# *institutional failure BBNJ was designed to avoid is playing out next door in real time.*

## STORY NOTES

The International Seabed Authority Council met 13-24 July 2026 in Kingston, Jamaica. NORI, a subsidiary of The Metals Company, received a five-year exploration contract extension for Pacific seabed blocks, opening a pathway toward future commercial mining applications.

Forty-five countries have now called for a moratorium or precautionary pause on

## STORY ARTICLE

State the contradiction plainly. A regulator extended a mining company's operating rights for five more years in the same session where it again failed to finish the rules that would govern what happens once exploration becomes extraction.

Four issues remain unresolved, and each carries real stakes. Benefit-sharing decides who gets paid when an area beyond any

deep-sea mining. As Pradeep Singh of the Oceano Azul Foundation put it: "The one thing for sure is that there's not going to be any adoption this year," referring to the Mining Code.

A parallel track sharpens the picture: TMC USA has pursued NOAA permits for the same areas outside the ISA framework since mid-2025, prompting an ISA compliance inquiry. ITLOS ruled on 18 July 2026 that the ISA could continue that inquiry while respecting due process. The next ISA

nation's jurisdiction gets mined. Scope decides whether the rules cover only polymetallic nodules or extend to seamounts and hydrothermal vents, entirely different ecosystems with different vulnerabilities. Sequencing decides whether environmental standards get set before or after exploitation applications start moving through the system.

Name the objection: is the NOAA/TMC USA parallel permitting track a deliberate attempt to undermine the

Council session is not until March 2027; the planned October 2026 meeting was cancelled. Unresolved Mining Code issues include benefit-sharing mechanisms, scope, and the timing of standards adoption.

**<https://news.mongabay.com/2026/07/un-regulator-delays-deep-sea-mining-rules-but-extends-criticized-exploration-contract/>**

multilateral process, or a genuine stress test of whether the ISA's authority holds when a major economy routes around it? The answer so far, via the ISA's compliance inquiry and the ITLOS ruling upholding it, is that the ISA's authority to investigate survives. The underlying jurisdictional standoff does not resolve.

The 45-country moratorium call is real counter-pressure, but the ISA Council does not need those states' support to keep operating on its current

track, which is precisely why the contract extension went through anyway.

Connect this directly to the BBNJ story in this same edition. Two multilateral ocean governance bodies are stuck at the institution-building stage at the same moment, in different ways. BBNJ's drafters were explicit about designing decision procedures to avoid the ISA's slow-consensus trap. The ISA's current session is the exact cautionary case study to cite when arguing that BBNJ's first

Conference of the Parties needs to hold that design line under real pressure, not only on paper.

This is not a clean story of island states against mining. Several Pacific SIDS, Nauru among them as NORI's own sponsoring state, depend on seabed mineral royalties as a hoped-for revenue source, which means the moratorium debate divides SIDS interests rather than uniting them the way BBNJ negotiations mostly did.

The next Council session is not until March 2027, a long runway during which an exploitation application could plausibly move faster than the rules meant to govern it. Whether that application gets filed before the rulebook exists is the thing worth tracking between now and then.

**<https://www.globalminingreview.com/mining/22042026/why-2026-will-decide-who-governs-the-seabed/>**

# SIDS Keep Writing "If Funded" Into Their Climate Plans. That's the Whole Problem.

---

*Ocean-based climate action remains significantly underfunded relative to country need, rising loss and damage, and the conditional ocean commitments SIDS have already written into their national climate plans.*

---

*The dialogue where governments discuss paying for ocean climate action met twice this year and still couldn't answer the one question that decides whether Seychelles gets ocean finance it can actually plan a budget around.*

#### STORY NOTES

The 2026 Ocean and Climate Change Dialogue convened for two afternoon sessions at the Bonn Climate Change Conference in June 2026, under the UNFCCC, with an informal summary report published 31 August 2026.

The core finding, drawn from that summary report: a significant share of parties, developing countries and SIDS especially, have written their ocean-related NDC actions as conditional on external support. Ocean-based climate action remains underfunded relative to country need and rising loss-and-damage exposure. SIDS called for special treatment in access to finance given their capacity constraints, and noted they receive only a small share of funding directed at SDG14.

No specific funding figure or committed mechanism came out of the dialogue, only a repeated statement of the underfunding problem. That vagueness is itself part of this story.

**<https://enb.iisd.org/ocean-and-climate-change-dialogue-2026>**

#### STORY ARTICLE

The tell in this year's dialogue outcome is not what it said. It is what it kept not saying. SIDS delegations wrote ocean-related actions into their national climate plans as conditional on external support again, the same hedge that recurs every cycle because reliable ocean finance still has not arrived to remove the need for it.

The Ocean and Climate Change Dialogue is an informal, non-negotiating UNFCCC space, convened twice a year, this year at the June Bonn session, meant to surface evidence and options that eventually feed into the Standing Committee on Finance and, from there, into formal COP decision text.

Name the objection: a dialogue that produces only an "informal summary report" is easy to dismiss as talk without teeth. But that is also how the Loss and Damage Fund's own groundwork was built, years of informal dialogue establishing the evidence base before Sharm el-Sheikh produced a binding decision. The informal stage is a precondition for the eventual mechanism, not a substitute for it.

The SDG14 underfunding point deserves honesty rather than an invented number. The dialogue's own materials describe SIDS receiving "a small share" of SDG14 funding, without attaching a specific percentage in the reporting available. That vagueness is worth naming directly rather than papering over, since it is part of why SIDS delegations can't build a budget line around this argument from one cycle to the next.

Years as a UNDP regional project manager and national IOC-UNESCO focal point put you on exactly this side of the table before, negotiating around conditional NDC language and chronic

ocean-finance uncertainty from the country side, not observing it from outside.

What would actually resolve this is a specific, quantified, ring-fenced ocean finance window tied to a defined disbursement mechanism, not another repetition of the underfunding finding at the next dialogue cycle. Worth tracking whether the Standing Committee on Finance picks this dialogue's findings up into a formal recommendation before the next COP.

<https://enb.iisd.org/ocean-and-climate-change-dialogue-2026>

STORY · 09

**The Ocean's Carbon Sink Could Flip to a Source. Nobody Has Written Rules for the Fix.**

*Two findings landed the same month saying the Southern Ocean's carbon sink could flip to a source on a plausible timeframe, and that the engineered fix for exactly that scenario has no governance framework built for it yet.*

#### STORY NOTES

A Science Advances study (Huiji Lee et al., 2026) modelled the Southern Ocean shifting from absorbing roughly 2.8 grams of carbon per square metre a year to releasing 8.5 to 8.6 grams, under both a net-zero and a sustained negative-emissions pathway, driven by persistent surface warming and declining seawater alkalinity. In the sustained negative-emissions scenario, the transition occurs around the year 2154. The study relies on a single climate model and excludes Antarctic ice sheet effects.

Separately, a National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine report published 21 September 2026 found that marine carbon dioxide removal, ocean alkalinity enhancement especially, faces major scientific uncertainty over how fast

alkaline material dissolves and pulls down CO<sub>2</sub>, and a real governance gap, since existing ocean law "was largely developed with other activities in mind."

The report's recommendation: build governance frameworks at international, national, and subnational levels now, and treat marine carbon dioxide removal as a complement to, never a substitute for, actual emissions cuts.

<https://phys.org/news/2026-09-southern-ocean-filip-carbon-source.html>

<https://news.climate.columbia.edu/2026/09/21/new-report-ocean-carbon-removal-shows-promise-but-big-questions-remain/>

#### STORY ARTICLE

Put the two findings side by side. A natural carbon sink that could fail on a multi-century timeline, and the leading engineered response to that kind of failure sitting with no governance rulebook behind it, reported within weeks of each other.

The Southern Ocean mechanism is precise: persistent surface warming combined with declining seawater alkalinity reverses the air-sea CO<sub>2</sub> pressure gradient, so the same water that currently pulls carbon out of the atmosphere would start pushing it back in. The numbers are stark, 2.8 grams absorbed against 8.5 to 8.6 grams released per square metre per year, but the caveats matter just as much: a single climate model, Antarctic ice sheet effects excluded, and a roughly 2154 timeline specific to the sustained-negative-emissions scenario.

Name the objection: a century-plus-out, single-model finding is easy to file under interesting but not urgent, decades removed from anything requiring a policy response now. But ocean alkalinity enhancement, the leading proposed remedy for exactly this kind of sink failure, is already being piloted on a research timeline measured in years, not centuries. That mismatch, how fast the proposed fix is moving against how far out the risk it addresses actually sits, is precisely

the condition under which deployment decisions get made before governance catches up.

The National Academies findings go deeper than "more research needed." There is a life-cycle accounting problem, no transparent, consistent standard exists to compare different carbon dioxide removal approaches against each other. There is an attribution problem, distinguishing removed carbon from natural ocean variability is genuinely hard. And there is a legal gap, existing marine law was not written with carbon removal in mind, so deploying at scale runs into rules built for entirely different activities, shipping, fishing, cable-laying, not carbon injection into the water column.

Draw the parallel to the ISA and BBNJ stories in this same edition directly. This is the same science-to-policy pattern playing out a third time in one news cycle: an activity with real deployment momentum outrunning the governance meant to constrain it, whether the activity is deep-sea

mining, high seas biodiversity protection, or ocean carbon removal.

This is a live governance space still worth occupying before rules calcify around it the way they did, or failed to, in Mining Code negotiations. Worth tracking specifically who convenes the first international governance discussion on marine carbon dioxide removal standards, since whoever writes the first framework sets the template everyone else works from.

<https://phys.org/news/2026-09-southern-ocean-filip-carbon-source.html>

STORY 10

# A UN Youth Climate Fund Opened Its First Oceans-and-

# SIDS Track. You Missed the Deadline.

*A UNDP-Italy youth climate fund opened its first dedicated Oceans and SIDS track this year, the application window already closed, and the reason it still matters is the talent pipeline it just created, not the grant itself.*

## STORY NOTES

The fourth edition of Youth4Climate's Call for Solutions, run by UNDP with the Government of Italy, introduced a dedicated "Oceans and Small Island Developing States" theme in 2026, open to innovators aged 18-29, especially from SIDS and coastal areas, addressing ocean protection or climate adaptation.

Grants of up to US\$30,000 in seed funding were available per project. Applications closed 30 April 2026; late or incomplete submissions were not reviewed.

Nothing here is actionable directly now: the deadline has passed and eligibility caps at 29. What is worth tracking is the signal it sends about where youth-led ocean-adaptation funding attention is moving, and the future talent and partnership pipeline it creates.

**<https://sdgs.un.org/partnerships/italy-finance-2026-youth4climate-call-solutions-oceans-and-sids>**

#### STORY ARTICLE

Name the miss plainly rather than softening it. This deadline came and went without landing on your radar. The honest reason to still cover it is not the grant you can no longer apply for. It's what its existence signals.

This is the first time in four editions that Youth4Climate has ring-fenced an Oceans and SIDS track specifically. That is a concrete signal that donor attention is shifting toward youth-led marine adaptation work in small island contexts in

particular, not ocean or SIDS funding in general terms.

Name the objection: thirty-thousand-dollar seed grants to individuals aged 18 to 29 look close to symbolic against the scale of the ocean finance gap described elsewhere in this edition (see story 08). But the actual value of funds structured like this rarely sits in the cheque size. It sits in the mentorship, global recognition, and cohort-building attached to it, which is a talent-pipeline argument, not a finance-scale one.

The connection to her own institutional footprint is direct. SHORE could plausibly engage graduates of a track like this as trainees or junior technical partners on hydrospatial projects, and Thrive Hub's personal-development mandate is a natural fit for mentoring exactly this age bracket and profile, especially from Seychelles or the wider Western Indian Ocean.

The concrete forward action is marking the calendar for the fifth edition, likely opening around

the first quarter of 2027 based on this year's pattern, and watching UNDP and Italy's own channels directly rather than relying on general climate-news searches to surface it, since that is precisely how this year's window was missed.

**<https://sdgs.un.org/partnerships/italy-finance-2026-youth4climate-call-solutions-oceans-and-sids>**

Morning Edition — compiled 26 September 2026 for Francesca Adrienne,  
SHORE Institute · Shorelines

Sources: ecomagazine.com / IOC-UNESCO, Commonwealth Secretariat,  
GEBCO / Seabed 2030, ORF, Mercator Ocean / Copernicus Marine, UNDP  
Mauritius-Seychelles, Mongabay / Global Mining Review, IISD Earth  
Negotiations Bulletin, Science Advances / phys.org, Columbia Climate School,  
UN SDG Partnerships.